

Report Number 3: Amplifying and consolidating women's leadership in local governance, peace, and security processes in Bungoma and Vihiga Counties.



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Mwanakombo Jarumani is a housewife-turned-keeper of peace in Kwale County, Kenya. Photo: UN Women Kenya

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To the Government of Ireland through the Embassy of Ireland in Kenya

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Acronyms and Abbreviations

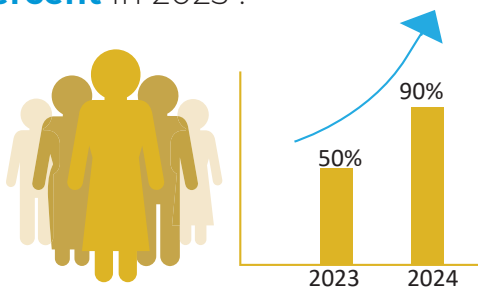
BETA - Bottom-Up Economic Transformation Agenda
CAP - County Action Plan
CECM - County Executive Committee Member
CGSWG(s) - County Gender Sector Working Group(s)
CSO - Civil Society Organization
ENAF - Echo Network Africa Foundation
EWER - Early Warning Early Response
FY - Financial Year
GBV - Gender-Based Violence
GEWE - Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment
GSWG(s) - Gender Sector Working Group(s)
KNAP II - Kenya National Action Plan II on Women, Peace, and Security
LNOB - Leave No One Behind
MP - Member of Parliament
MTP-IV - Medium-Term Plan IV
NCCCK - National Council of Churches of Kenya
NGSWG - National Gender Sector Working Group
OHCHR - Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights
SDG(s) - Sustainable Development Goal(s)
SGBV - Sexual and Gender-Based Violence
UN - United Nations
UN Women - United Nations Entity for Gender Equality and the Empowerment of Women
UNSCR 1325 - United Nations Security Council Resolution 1325
UNSDCF - United Nations Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework
WHRDs - Women Human Rights Defenders
WPS - Women, Peace, and Security
WRO - Women, Peace, and Security

Executive Summary

This is the final report for the phase II project “Amplifying and consolidating women’s leadership in local governance, peace, and security processes in Bungoma and Vihiga counties,” implemented by UN Women in partnership with the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR), Echo Network Africa Foundation (ENAF), and the National Council of Churches of Kenya (NCCCK) through the generous support from the Government of Ireland. The report covers the 2024 implementation period, where UN Women and its partners implemented interventions aimed at advancing the role of women in peace, security, and governance processes.

In 2024, women in Bungoma and Vihiga Counties moved from the margins of public life to actively shaping local governance, peace, and security processes. More women are now speaking up, influencing policy, and holding county governments accountable. This shift was most visible in the peace and leadership spaces, where women transitioned from passive participants to credible decision-makers.

In the peace and security sector, **90 percent** of targeted women reported increased capacity and agency—up from **50 percent** in 2023.

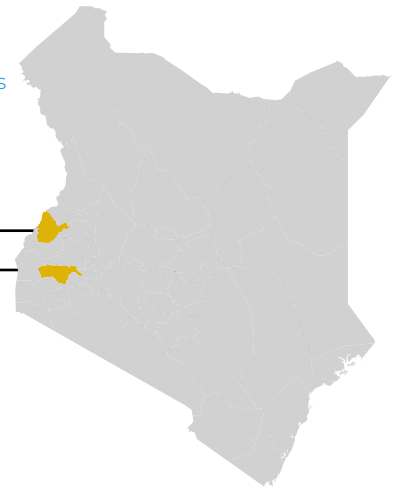


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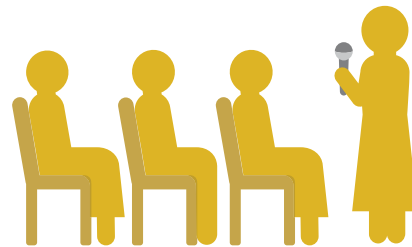
Amplifying and consolidating women's leadership in local governance, peace, and security processes Project

Bungoma

Vihiga



Women peace actors played leading roles in conflict resolution, budget advocacy, and formal peace structures. In Mt. Elgon, women led a review of the Mabanga Peace Accord with their recommendations formally endorsed by the Supreme Council of Elders. In **Vihiga, 30 women** submitted a gender-responsive peace memorandum to the Deputy Governor, while others convened Early Warning Early Response forums across four sub-counties. These are signs that women’s leadership in peacebuilding is gaining both legitimacy and institutional support.



Women's leadership in peacebuilding is gaining both legitimacy and institutional support.

1 This is based on evidence through triangulated findings from partner progress reports, training session feedback, and field monitoring observations

2 The Mabanga Peace Declaration promotes peaceful elections, inclusive dialogue, and collective commitment to non-violence, unity, and gender-responsive peacebuilding across communities

3 Gender Mainstreaming Policy in Bungoma, Bungoma County Disability Mainstreaming Policy, Bungoma County Children Policy, Vihiga SGBV Policy

4 The policies promote inclusive services, GBV prevention, gender-responsive planning, data systems, and community partnerships to advance equality, protect rights, and ensure access for women, children, persons with disabilities, and diverse groups

On governance and political participation, **1,292 women** gained leadership skills, exceeding the target of **1,000**. Women are now more confident engaging with county structures, influencing public dialogue, and preparing to contest in the 2027 elections. Their priorities—captured in county-level Women’s Manifestos—are no longer just advocacy tools but key priorities. Four of these priorities were translated into formal county policies, including on gender mainstreaming, disability inclusion, and child protection.



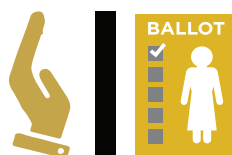
On governance and political participation, 1,292 women gained leadership skills, exceeding the target of 1,000.

County Gender Sector Working Groups operationalized dedicated Women’s Leadership Pillars, creating permanent spaces to address structural barriers to women’s representation.



The political behavior of county governments also shifted for instance, in the two counties, they adopted seven gender-responsive commitments signaling increased institutional accountability to women’s voices. County Gender Sector Working Groups operationalized dedicated Women’s Leadership Pillars, creating permanent spaces to address structural barriers to women’s representation. County officials are now more receptive to women’s leadership, and public planning spaces have become more inclusive.

Lessons learned include the persistence of cultural resistance to women’s leadership, the gap between policy adoption and implementation, and the power of peer-led learning in building women’s agency.



Persistence of cultural resistance to women’s leadership

The gap between policy adoption and implementation.



Next steps will focus on supporting implementation of enacted policies, scaling use of Women’s Manifestos for accountability, operationalizing the Women’s Leadership Academy, and introducing youth-focused components.

A Rapid Gender Analysis will inform engagement strategies ahead of the 2027 elections, ensuring young and grassroots women are better positioned for political participation.



The power of peer-led learning in building women’s agency.

Strategic Purpose

Theory of change

The project aimed to strengthen women's meaningful participation and influence in governance, peace, and security decision-making processes at sub-county and county levels in Bungoma and Vihiga counties. The project's results pathway was anchored on the following Theory of Change:

IF women and non-state actors are equipped with safe spaces, resources, and enhanced capacities to engage in governance, peace, and security processes; And **IF** protective mechanisms are established and operational to uphold the fundamental rights of women and girls and ensure their freedom from gender-based violence; And **IF** communities and institutions embrace and practice gender equality as a social norm; **THEN** gender equality commitments, including those under the Women, Peace, and Security (WPS) agenda, will be more effectively implemented in Bungoma and Vihiga.

Strategic Alignment

The project is fully aligned with the current UN Women Kenya Strategic Note 2023-2026 and the United Nations Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework (UNSDCF) 2022-2026 (Strategic Priority 1: People and Peace, outcomes: 1.1 and 1.2, which have been adopted verbatim). The Strategic Note and the UNSDCF fully respond to the Leaving No One Behind (LNOB) principle.

The project is further aligned with the key Government priorities, including the Kenya Constitution (2010), the Bottom-Up Economic Transformation Agenda (BETA), the Medium-Term Plan IV (MTP-IV), the Vision 2030, as well as the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).



Kwale Beneficiary (Women Peace Champion Engaging the neighbour on matters peace). Photo: UN Women Kenya

New Developments

In 2024, Kenya experienced nationwide protests from the youth, popularly known as Gen-Z, as they demanded transparency, economic reforms, and greater political accountability. Sparked by frustration over rising living costs, public debt, and governance failures, the protests signaled a generational shift in civic engagement. In Bungoma and Vihiga counties, these national dynamics intensified local tensions between citizens and security forces, while also catalyzing community dialogues around justice, inclusion, and responsive leadership.

Sparked by frustration over rising living costs, public debt, and governance failures, the protests signaled a generational shift in civic engagement.

On June 25, 2024, demonstrations in Bungoma County against the Finance Bill led to at least one youth being shot and several others being arrested. Reports also surfaced political interference, with politicians accused of hiring goons to disrupt the youth-led protests. In what seemed to be a response to the demonstrations, Governor Ken Lusaka announced a major cabinet reshuffle to make the government more responsive to citizens' needs.

The reshuffle included reassignments across key portfolios, such as **gender, youth, health, agriculture, trade, and education.**

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On women's political participation and leadership, women leaders in Bungoma and Vihiga counties remained active in governance and public life in 2024. **For example, in Bungoma County, County MP Hon. Catherine Wambilianga spearheaded countywide efforts to tackle rising cases of Gender-Based Violence (GBV) through sports.** Through the 'Zero Tolerance to GBV' football tournament, she reached all **45** wards, using the platform to raise awareness about GBV and the alarming increase in teenage pregnancies.



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5 <https://nation.africa/kenya/news/gen-z-protests-a-revolution-aided-by-technology--4669846>

6 <https://www.the-star.co.ke/counties/coast/2024-06-18-lusaka-reshuffles-cabinet-appoints-new-chief-officers>

7 <https://www.the-star.co.ke/news/2024-08-19-wambilianga-banks-on-football-tourney-in-gbv-fight>

This level of visibility and grassroots engagement strengthened public accountability, normalized women's leadership in traditionally male-dominated spaces, and mobilized community action against GBV.

It also demonstrated how women leaders are not only occupying positions of power but are using them to champion urgent social issues and bridge gaps between policy and community realities. Similarly, in Vihiga County, on December 11, 2024, the County Executive Member (CECM) for Social Services, Anne Desma, led the county in launching the Sexual Gender Based Violence and Child Protection policies. The policies, developed with support from UN Women and OHCHR under the Irish-Aid 2024 project, provide a legal framework for addressing the high incidences of GBV, as well as child neglect and molestation in the county.

The CECM has been a big advocate for gender equality and women's empowerment, working closely with UN Women to address critical gender issues in the county and demonstrating the value women leaders bring to decision-making spaces.

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Peace junior club teacher champion.
Photo: UN Women Kenya

Key partnerships

In 2024, UN Women continued its partnership with the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) in the joint implementation of the project. The partnership capitalized on the unique strengths of each UN Agency in peacebuilding efforts, emphasizing women's participation and the protection and promotion of human rights and freedoms.

To achieve the project's objectives, UN Women and OHCHR effectively brought together various stakeholders, including government representatives, civil society, peace committees, and women human rights defenders at the county and sub-county levels. Additionally, UN Women and OHCHR provided advisory support to civil society organizations (CSOs) and women's rights organizations (WROs) to help formulate strategies and implement project activities.

In 2024, UN Women and OHCHR collaborated with three implementing partners - the National Council of Churches in Kenya (NCCK), Echo Network Africa Foundation (ENAF), and the CSO Network. These partners implemented initiatives focused on women's political participation and the Women, Peace, and Security (WPS) agenda. See Annex 1 for a summary of each partner's contribution.

Results

In 2024, Kenya ranked 75th globally in the Gender Gap Index, with a political empowerment score of 21 percent, up from 11.4 percent in 2023. Despite this progress, women remain underrepresented in decision-making spaces, and the constitutional two-thirds gender principle remains unfulfilled.

Simultaneously, *Kenya's Global Peace Index ranking declined from 113th in 2021 to 122nd in 2024*, reflecting a gradual drop over three years, signaling increased insecurity and fragile social cohesion.



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Kenya's Global Peace Index ranking declined from 113th in 2021 to 122nd in 2024

In this context, UN Women, with support from Ireland, continued to address structural barriers to women's political participation by enhancing their capacities to take on leadership roles and contribute to governance, peace, and security processes at county and sub-county levels. These developments highlight the continued relevance of the project's Theory of Change, which centers on creating safe, inclusive, and gender-responsive spaces, strengthening women's agencies, and promoting institutional accountability.

Below are the key results achieved by the project in 2024. Instructively, the results are presented below against the results areas (Outcomes and Outputs) and their respective indicators.

8 <https://www.kenyanews.go.ke/vihiga-county-launches-anti-gender-based-violence-policy/>

9 https://www3.weforum.org/docs/WEF_GGGR_2024.pdf

10 <https://www.economicsandpeace.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/GPI-2024-web.pdf>

Outcome 1: Women have enhanced capacities to participate in leadership roles and contribute to decision making processes at county and sub-county level on governance, peace and security

Commitments to adopt gender priority issues

In 2024, Bungoma and Vihiga county governments demonstrated strengthened political commitment and institutional responsiveness to gender equality by making seven formal commitments to adopt gender priority issues identified by women's networks, surpassing the annual target of six. The seven gender priority commitments drawn from the reviewed policies in Bungoma and Vihiga counties focus on mainstreaming gender and child protection concerns into county governance and service delivery.

First, **(i)** the Gender Mainstreaming Policy in Bungoma prioritizes equal access to health, education, leadership, and economic opportunities, while addressing GBV, ICT inclusion, and climate change from a gender lens.

Second, **(ii)** the Bungoma County Disability Mainstreaming Policy ensures persons with disabilities, especially women and youth, access services, employment, infrastructure, and are protected in emergencies. Third, **(iii)** the Bungoma County Children Policy in both counties emphasize children's survival, development, protection, and participation rights. Fourth, **(iv)** the Vihiga SGBV Policy strengthens institutional responses to sexual and gender-based violence, focusing on prevention, survivor support, and coordinated systems. Fifth, **(v)** Bungoma Gender Mainstreaming and Vihiga SGBV policies commit to building inclusive institutions that integrate gender equality in planning, budgeting, and service delivery.



UWIANO Peace Champion. Photo: UN Women Kenya

Sixth, (vi) the policies promote gender-responsive data systems and research to inform evidence-based decisions, track inequalities, and ensure accountability for outcomes affecting women, girls, boys, and persons of diverse gender identities. Lastly, (vii) the policies institutionalize inclusive, community-driven partnerships that amplify women's voices and leadership, strengthen women's rights organizations, and foster collective accountability for advancing gender equality.

The above results reflect a tangible shift in how local governments engage with and respond to women-led advocacy, moving beyond consultation to concrete institutional action.

The adoption of gender-responsive frameworks — including county action plans on UNSCR 1325, SGBV and child protection policies, and gender and disability mainstreaming strategies — illustrates increased alignment between policy decisions and the lived realities and priorities of women at the community level.

These commitments signal growing recognition of women as legitimate decision-makers and peace actors and demonstrate positive changes in county-level political will, institutional behavior, and openness to inclusive governance. The active engagement of women peace actors in shaping these policies further signals a rise in their confidence, policy influence, and public legitimacy. Together, these shifts are breaking down structural barriers and contributing to more equitable, inclusive, and accountable governance and peacebuilding systems.

These results were achieved through sustained engagement with the respective county governments, strategic advocacy by women's networks, and capacity-strengthening efforts that enabled women leaders and peace actors to articulate and defend their priorities. Platforms for structured dialogue and inclusive consultations helped translate women lived experiences into actionable policy proposals, while targeted technical support ensured these proposals met county planning and legislative standards.

Together, these shifts are breaking down structural barriers and contributing to more equitable, inclusive, and accountable governance and peacebuilding systems.

Notably, women peace actors contributed directly to efforts addressing conflict in Mt. Elgon, reinforcing the value of women-led approaches to local peace and security. UN Women in collaboration with OHCHR and ENAF, played a critical role by providing technical assistance, facilitating multi-stakeholder dialogue, and supporting the development of inclusive policy frameworks. UN Women also invested in building the capacity of women leaders and community-based networks to engage with duty bearers, influence county agendas, and hold institutions accountable to gender equality and peace commitments. The results reaffirm the continued relevance of the project's Theory of Change, which emphasizes the need for inclusive spaces, protective mechanisms, and gender-responsive institutions to advance women's leadership in governance, peace, and security.

¹¹ See the policy in annex 2

¹² Ibid 7

¹³ Ibid 7

¹⁴ Ibid 7

Women participate in governance and peace building processes

Women engaged through the project are now actively participating in peacebuilding, governance, and social cohesion processes, demonstrating a significant shift in women's agency, leadership, and public influence at the county level. For instance, women peace actors, including grassroots leaders and Women Human Rights Defenders (WHRDs), moved from being passive observers to strategic influencers—shaping peace agreements, contributing to budget processes, and driving community-level conflict prevention efforts. In Bungoma County, women from Mt. Elgon played a central role in the review of the Mabanga Peace Accord, developing formal recommendations that were later endorsed by the Supreme Council of Elders



UN Women Champion. Photo: UN Women Kenya

In Vihiga County, thirty women peace actors developed and submitted a gender-responsive Memorandum to the Deputy Governor, calling for the inclusion of Women, Peace and Security (WPS) priorities in the FY 2025/26 Annual Development Plan. Women also led Early Warning Early Response (EWER) forums across four sub-counties (Emuhaya, Vihiga, Luanda, and Sabatia), positioning themselves as trusted frontline actors in peace and security initiatives.

This level of engagement reflects the achievement of a key project milestone, with **90 percent** of women demonstrating strengthened capacity, significantly surpassing the annual target of **70 percent** under the project's outcome indicator.



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These results were made possible through *UN Women sustained technical and strategic support, delivered in partnership with OHCHR, NCKK, and the CSO Network, and with funding from the Government of Ireland*. UN Women played a convening role in facilitating safe and inclusive spaces for women's engagement, supported training on the localization of KNAP II and the Women, Peace and Security agenda, and strengthened coordination mechanisms such as peace committees and County Gender Sector Working Groups.

The project also enabled peer learning among women leaders and duty bearers, reinforced GBV and peace referral pathways, and provided targeted technical assistance to women peace actors to develop policy recommendations and advocacy tools. By linking grassroots women with decision-makers and formal planning processes, UN Women helped translate enhanced capacity into sustained political engagement and institutional responsiveness.

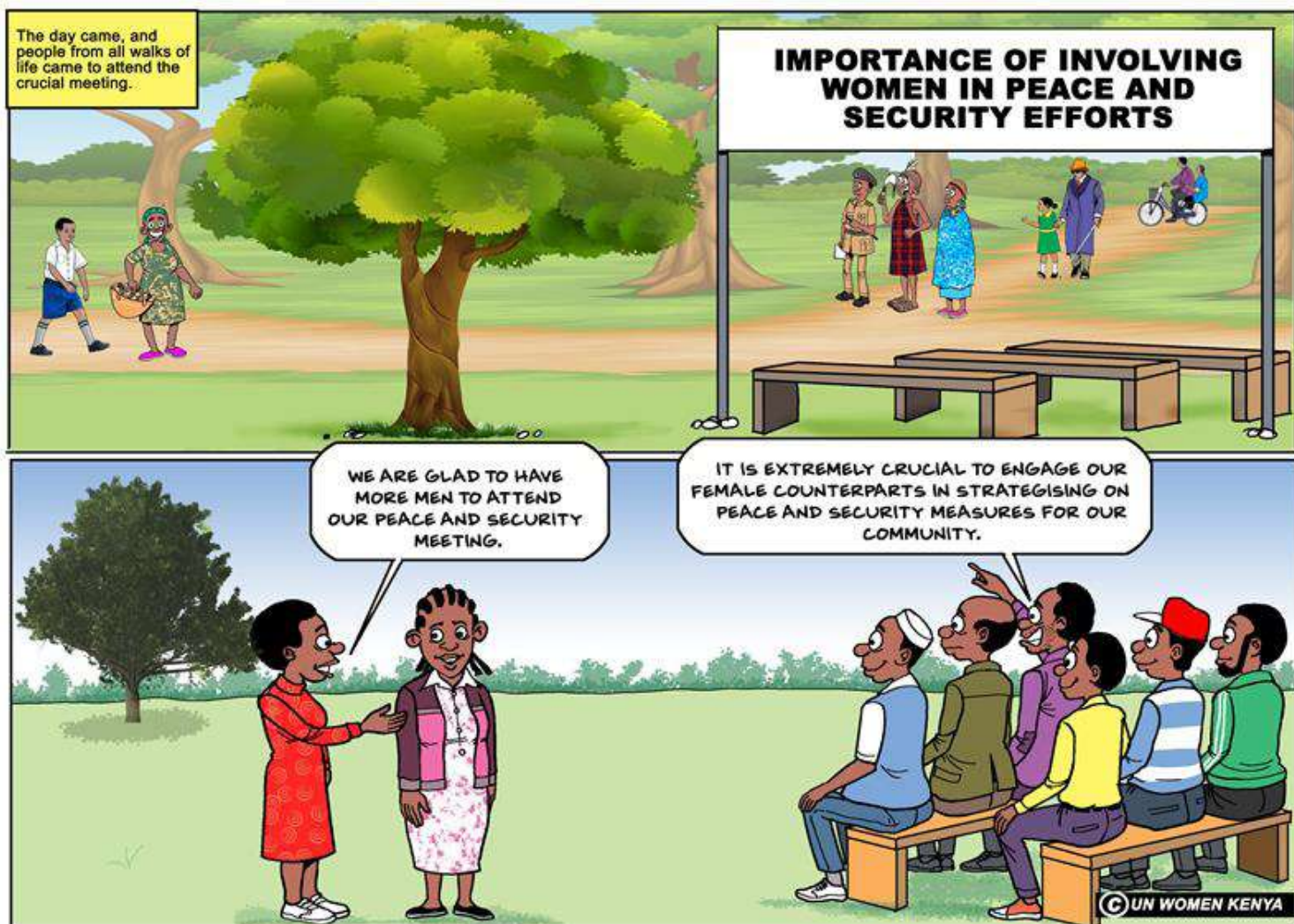
Table 1: Indicators of Achievement Outcome 1:-Women have enhanced capacities to participate in leadership roles and contribute to decision making processes at county and sub-county level on governance, peace and security

Impact Area/ Outcome/Output	Indicators	Baseline 2023	End of Project Target	End of project Achieved	Target Status
Outcome 1: Women have enhanced capacities to participate in leadership roles and contribute to decision making processes at county and sub-county level on governance, peace and security	Number of commitments made by the two county governments to adopt gender priority issues identified by the women networks	4	6	7	Surpassed ¹⁷
	Percentage of women who indicate strengthened capacity to a) participate in governance and development processes b) in conflict prevention, peace building and social cohesion processes, at the county level	50%	70%	90%	Surpassed ¹⁸

¹⁵ See memorandum in the annexes

¹⁶ This is based on evidence through triangulated findings from partner progress reports, training session feedback, and field monitoring observations

¹⁷ See explanation in annex 5



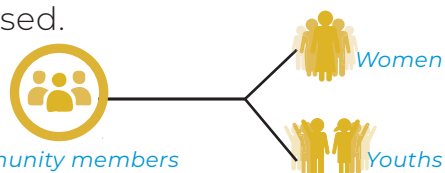
Output 1:1. Increasing the role and agency of women leaders at grassroots level for meaningful engagement and participation in peace and security processes in Bungoma and Vihiga Counties

Implementation of the County Action plans

In 2024, Bungoma and Vihiga counties actively implemented their respective County Action Plans (CAPs) on UNSCR 1325, achieving the annual target of two CAPs under implementation. These action plans serve as blueprints for advancing gender-responsive peace and security by addressing systemic drivers of conflict, including land and resource-based tensions and widespread Gender-Based Violence (GBV), while institutionalizing women's leadership in governance and peacebuilding.

Their implementation marks a shift from policy commitment to action, with women's voices now shaping how counties prevent, respond to, and resource local peace and security priorities. In Bungoma, women peace actors led mediation efforts in Cheptais Sub-County, helping to de-escalate inter-communal tensions through inclusive dialogue and community-led resolution. In Vihiga, women engaged in budget advocacy, successfully lobbying for increased allocation to women- and GBV-focused initiatives, ensuring that peacebuilding also responds to protection and justice needs.

Additionally, 115 community members, including 98 women and 10 youth, participated in dissemination forums for the Vihiga CAP across Emuhaya, Vihiga, Luanda, and Sabatia sub-counties, strengthening grassroots ownership and public accountability. The active rollout of these plans signals that the counties are moving toward more inclusive governance systems—where the structural exclusion of women from peace and security processes is being reversed.



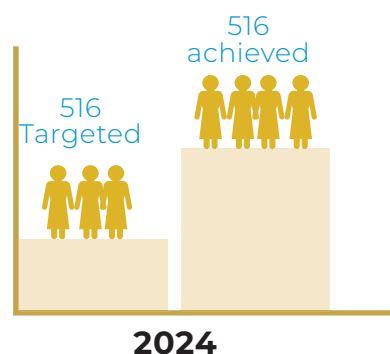
115 community members, including 98 women and 10 youth, participated in dissemination forums, strengthening grassroots ownership and public accountability.

Instructively, the CAPs offer a replicable model for localizing the Women, Peace and Security agenda in devolved governance structures. One key opportunity lies in integrating CAP priorities into mainstream county development plans and budgets to ensure sustainability. A critical lesson learned is the importance of pairing policy adoption with continuous capacity support to grassroots women, ensuring that implementation translates into real shifts in power, inclusion, and accountability.

UN Women, with financial support from the Government of Ireland and in close collaboration with OHCHR and NCCK, played a central role in facilitating the implementation of both action plans. This included providing technical assistance to county governments, strengthening coordination with local peace actors, and supporting advocacy, dialogue, and community sensitization efforts. UN Women also ensured the alignment of the CAPs with KNAP II and the specific peace and security priorities of each county, anchoring local action within a broader national and global WPS framework.

Capacity to participate in peace, and security processes

In 2024, a total of 516 beneficiaries, surpassing the annual target of 500, this demonstrated increased capacity to participate in governance, peace, and security processes across Bungoma and Vihiga counties. The majority were women peace actors, grassroots leaders, and Women Human Rights Defenders (WHRDs), who strengthened their skills in mediation, advocacy, gender-responsive budgeting, and inclusive policy dialogue. As a result, women are now actively engaging with county leadership, contributing to peace and governance processes, and articulating community priorities with increased confidence and technical knowledge.



In 2024, a total of 516 beneficiaries, surpassing the annual target of 500, this demonstrated increased capacity to participate in governance, peace, and security processes across Bungoma and Vihiga counties. The majority were

In Bungoma, empowered women peace actors from Mt. Elgon led a strategic review of the Mabanga Peace Declaration, which had historically excluded women's voices. Through the review process, they identified critical gaps and formulated recommendations that reflect their strengthened understanding of policy development, protection mechanisms, and inclusive peacebuilding.

¹⁸ Ibid 11

¹⁹ <https://africa.unwomen.org/en/stories/news/2024/03/vihiga-county-launches-unscr-1325-action-plan-for-women-peace-and-security>

These included the formalization of the Mabanga Declaration into a policy framework, the strengthening of women's leadership and advocacy capacities, enhanced engagement between women leaders and the Council of Elders, the development of targeted GBV prevention and response programmes, support for land dispute mediation, youth-focused peace initiatives, and the translation of the Peace Declaration into local languages to improve accessibility and community ownership.

The endorsement of these recommendations by the Supreme Council of Elders marked a key milestone that demonstrates that women's contributions are now shaping formal peace frameworks. In Vihiga, women demonstrated their enhanced capacity through budget advocacy, specifically the development and submission of a gender-responsive Memorandum to the County Government. The document proposed the integration of gender-

focused initiatives in the FY 2025/26 Annual Development Plan, covering all four pillars of UNSCR1325, and emphasized data systems, participatory budgeting, and capacity building for women's engagement in county planning processes.

These results were achieved through targeted capacity-strengthening efforts led by UN Women, in partnership with OHCHR, NCKK, and the CSO Network, and funded by the Government of Ireland. Trainings on KNAP II localization, GBV referral systems, peace architecture coordination, and policy advocacy equipped women with the practical skills to engage more effectively in formal governance and peace structures. The project moved beyond awareness-raising to enable hands-on application of skills, empowering women not just to participate, but to lead, shape, and influence the peace and development agenda in their counties.

Table 2: Indicators of Achievement: Output 1:1. Increasing the role and agency of women leaders at grassroots level for meaningful engagement and participation in peace and security processes in Bungoma and Vihiga Counties

Impact Area/ Outcome/ Output	Indicators	Baseline 2023	End of Project Target	End of project Achieved	Target Status
Output 1:1. Increasing the role and agency of women leaders at grassroots level for meaningful engagement and participation in peace and security processes in Bungoma and Vihiga Counties	Indicator 1.1.a. Number of County Action plans being implemented.	0	2	2	Achieved
	Indicator 1.1.b. Number of beneficiaries with increased capacities to participate in governance, peace, and security processes ³	300	500	516	Surpassed ²¹

20 <https://test.pax.peaceagreements.org/agreements/1947/coding/Mabanga%20Peace%20Accord>

21 Ibid 11

Output 1.2: Women leaders have increased capacity to participate in governance processes at the county and sub-county levels in Bungoma and Vihiga

Operationalization of leadership pillars

In 2024, UN Women, in collaboration with ENAF and the Bungoma and Vihiga county governments, supported the implementation of two (2) Women's Leadership Pillars against an indicator target of two (2) within the County Gender Sector Working Groups (CGSWG) in Bungoma and Vihiga counties. This marked a significant institutional shift, positioning women's leadership as a permanent agenda item within county-level gender coordination mechanisms. The pillars are strengthening the counties' ability to identify and act on persistent barriers to women's participation in political and decision-making spaces. Early shifts are evident in the stronger articulation of women's priorities during CGSWG meetings and growing consensus to address structural barriers, including through collective commitments to increase women's representation in the 2027 County Assemblies.

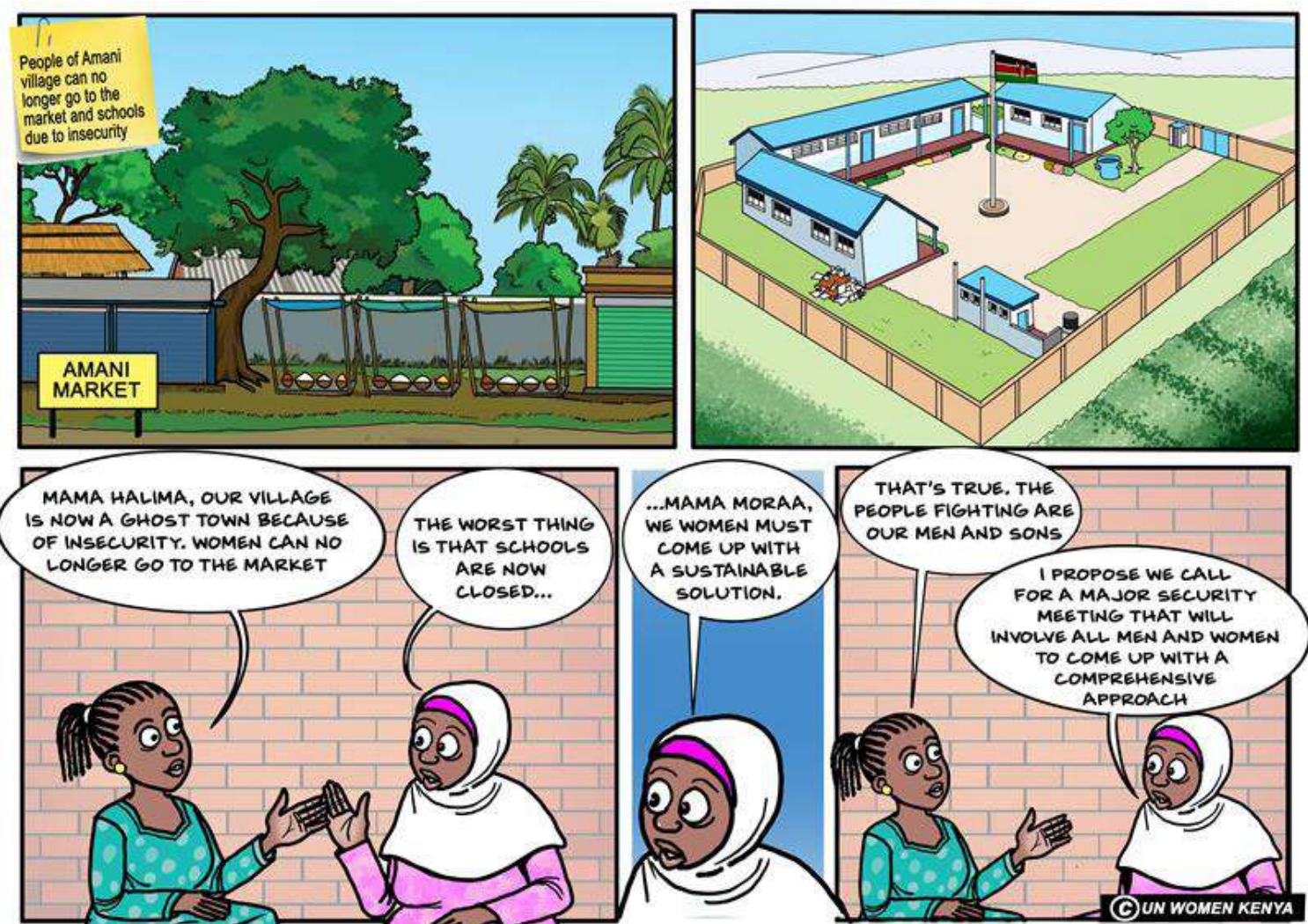
Operationalization of leadership pillars aligns with the UN Women-supported National Gender Sector Working Group (NGSWG) framework, which is structured around four thematic pillars: Women, Peace and Security; Women's Economic Empowerment; Gender-Based Violence; and Women's Leadership, along with a newly introduced Male Engagement pillar. To support operationalization, UN Women and ENAF convened structured engagement forums in both counties, drawing together CGSWG members, civil society actors, and elected leaders to jointly define opportunities, challenges, and entry points for strengthening women's leadership.



Women Peace Champion in Kwale County. Photo: UN Women Kenya

UN Women and ENAF further provided technical support to develop two county-specific Women's Leadership Strategy documents. These strategies provide a detailed analysis of the current status of women's leadership in Bungoma and Vihiga, the barriers that continue to undermine women's political participation, and clear, actionable pathways to strengthen women's roles in governance and leadership. These strategy documents now serve as blueprints for action under the newly instituted pillars, guiding county stakeholders in advancing a gender-responsive and inclusive leadership agenda.

With continued support from the Government of Ireland, UN Women remains a key technical partner, ensuring alignment with national priorities and providing capacity-building and advisory support to sustain implementation. In 2025, UN Women and ENAF will continue working with the CGSWG members to strengthen the CGSWGs' work under the newly instituted Women's Leadership Pillars, using the two strategies as guiding documents.



Capacities to participate in governance, leadership, and decision-making processes

In 2024, a total of 1,292 women, surpassing the target of 1,000, acquired enhanced knowledge and skills to actively engage in governance, leadership, and decision-making processes across Bungoma and Vihiga counties. With improved confidence, public speaking abilities, and understanding of gender-responsive leadership, women are now better positioned to contest elective seats, influence policy discussions, and participate in county planning forums. This capacity strengthening reflects growing momentum to shift women from the periphery to the center of political dialogue and public leadership. It is expected that this foundational capacity will contribute to greater visibility of women candidates in the 2027 elections and sustained influence in shaping county governance priorities.



In 2024, a total of 1,292 women, surpassing the target of 1,000, acquired enhanced knowledge and skills to actively engage in governance, leadership, and decision-making processes across Bungoma and Vihiga counties.

A direct result of these strengthened capacities was the development of Women's Manifestos by the empowered women in both counties. These manifestos articulate community-driven priorities and policy asks, including increased budget allocations for GBV prevention and response, enforcement of the two-thirds gender rule in public appointments, improved access to

sexual and reproductive health services, economic empowerment for women and girls, and stronger representation of women in county decision-making structures.

To ensure accessibility, the manifestos were translated into Swahili, abridged, and 220 copies disseminated through community forums. This expanded grassroots awareness and provided women with practical advocacy tools to demand accountability and advance the gender equality agenda within public governance platforms.

In parallel, progress was made toward the establishment of a Women's Leadership Academy, envisioned as a long-term training hub for women leaders across the Lake Region Economic Bloc. UN Women and ENAF facilitated a Training of Trainers program that equipped 12 resource persons drawn from county government officials, elected women leaders, and lecturers from Kibabii and Kaimosi universities with practical skills in gender advocacy and political leadership.

These trainers will support the rollout of the Academy, starting with leadership mentorship sessions for female university students in 2025. The Academy is expected to further institutionalize capacity building for women leaders and embed gender-transformative leadership models in county institutions.

22 See annex 3 on how the pillars are being strengthen

Implementation of GEWE priorities from manifestos

In 2024, five gender equality and women's empowerment (GEWE) priorities outlined in the Bungoma and Vihiga Women's Manifestos were translated into formal county-level policy instruments, surpassing the annual target of four. These include the Bungoma County Gender Mainstreaming Policy, Disability Mainstreaming Policy, and Children Policy, and the Vihiga County Sexual and Gender-Based Violence (SGBV) Policy and Child Protection and Welfare Policy.

Their enactment marks a shift from community advocacy to formal policy integration, embedding locally identified gender priorities into governance frameworks. The enacted policies address systemic gender gaps by institutionalizing inclusive governance, promoting equal access to services, and enhancing accountability for protecting vulnerable populations. The Gender and Disability Mainstreaming Policies promote equity in access and representation across public sectors.

The Children and Child Protection Policies provide protection measures for at-risk children, while the Vihiga SGBV Policy establishes clear standards for preventing and responding to violence against women and girls. Together, the policies enable focused public investment and legal accountability to GEWE outcomes.

The operationalization of these policies is already generating results. In Vihiga, the SGBV Policy has laid the groundwork for budget proposals targeting survivor protection, including support for the operationalization of the Mbale Rescue Centre. In Bungoma, the Gender Mainstreaming Policy now guides sector

planning and budgeting, requiring departments to integrate gender considerations into county development priorities. These changes are critical for institutional responsiveness, ensuring that women and girls benefit equitably from public resources.

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The Disability Policy explicitly recognizes the double discrimination faced by women and girls with disabilities and sets out inclusive strategies to address their needs.

The Child Protection Policies, meanwhile, prioritize safeguarding girls from abuse, neglect, and harmful cultural practices, closing long-standing protection gaps at the community level.

The policies are at different stages of implementation. In Vihiga, the SGBV and Child Protection Policies were approved by the County Assembly and launched during the 16 Days of Activism. Budget proposals aligned with the policies are under review. In Bungoma, the three policies were enacted and gazetted in 2024, with implementation commencing through the alignment of departmental plans and budgets.

²³ See annex 4 for the manifestos

²⁴ Ibid 7

UN Women, in partnership with ENAF and with support from Ireland, provided technical support throughout the policy development process. This included facilitating stakeholder consultations, providing gender analysis and advisory inputs, and supporting engagement between civil society and government actors.

These efforts were instrumental in translating the Women's Manifesto asks into policy instruments that reflect the lived realities of women and girls in both counties.

Table 3: Indicators of Achievement: Output 1.2: Women leaders have increased capacity to participate in governance processes at County and sub-county level in Bungoma and Vihiga Counties

Impact Area/ Outcome/ Output	Indicators	Baseline 2023	End of Project Target	End of project Achieved	Target Status
Output 1.2: Women leaders have increased capacity to participate in governance processes at County and sub-county level in Bungoma and Vihiga Counties	Indicator 2.1a Number of leadership pillars in the Vihiga and Bungoma County Gender Sector Working Group operationalized.	0	2	2	Achieved
	Indicator 2.2.b. Number of beneficiaries with increased capacities to participate in Governance, leadership and decision-making processes.	500	100	1292	Surpassed ²⁵
	Indicator 2.1c. Number of GEWE priorities being implemented from the launched women's manifestos.	0	4(per county)	5 (3 Bungoma policies and 2 Vihiga policies)	Surpassed ²⁶

²⁵ Ibid 11

²⁶ Ibid 11

Challenges and Lessons Learned

During the period under review, the project encountered several challenges as summarized below:

Deeply entrenched cultural norms and stereotypes continue to undermine women's leadership in Bungoma and Vihiga counties. Women in public office or those aspiring for such offices often face skepticism from their communities, as most traditions favor male leadership over female leadership. Further cultural resistance is often compounded by low representation of women in influential spaces such as the Chiefs Barazas and Land Control Boards. These traditional barriers discourage women from participating in public and political life and leave them vulnerable to intimidation, especially during periods of heightened political activity.

Limited access to economic empowerment opportunities and the high cost of politics presents significant financial barriers to women aspiring for political office. This impacts their capacity to run competitive campaigns or implement community initiatives to enhance their visibility within these communities.

Structural and institutional gaps exist, including the under-resourcing of peace chapters and CGSWGs, which limits their ability to effectively influence policies and the decision-making process. For instance, while SGBV referral pathways are in place, they are often not supported by safe houses or psychological care,

particularly at the community level.

On the positive end, the project demonstrated that strong partnerships and local ownership can yield meaningful gains. The project's sustained engagement with community structures, including religious leaders, women peace actors, male champions, and political leaders, helped break down the cultural resistance and encourage dialogue. Further, the Women's Manifestos and County Action Plans on UNSCR 1325 served as crucial advocacy tools for women community leaders in the two counties, thus amplifying their voices and creating visibility for the women.

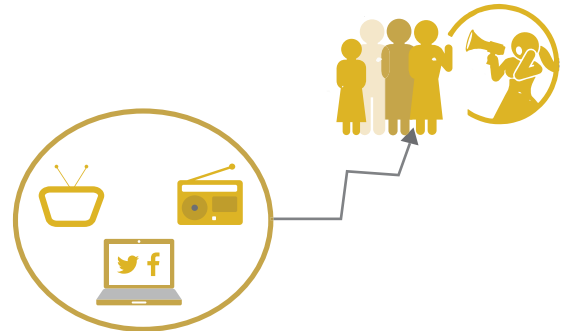
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Next Steps



In response to the Challenges and Lessons Learned noted above, UN Women is re-engaging OHCHR and ENAF to support the implementation of the 2025 phase. Building on the achievements and lessons learned from previous projects, the proposed 2025 project will prioritize advancing the Women, Peace, and Security (WPS) agenda by engaging stakeholders in developing the third phase of the Kenya National Action Plan on Women, Peace, and Security.

The 2025 project will also introduce a media and visibility component through collaboration with national and local media to enhance gender-sensitive conflict reporting. Furthermore, by strengthening coordination within the Gender Sector Working Groups (GSWGs) in the two counties, the project will ensure the integration of gender-responsive strategies into peace and security initiatives.

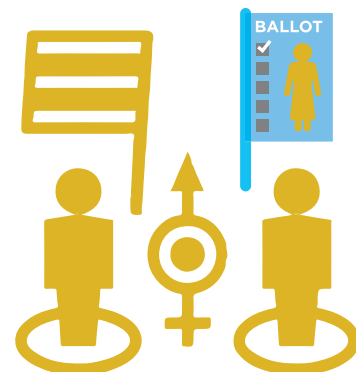


On governance, the project will enhance women's roles in decision-making processes at the sub-county and ward levels by disseminating the Women's Manifestos developed during the last iteration of the project, whose interventions were many and focused at the policy level. By taking this year's interventions to the community level, the project will equip women at that local level with the information and skills needed to hold their respective county governments accountable for their gender commitments.

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To inform women's political participation interventions in the lead-up to the 2027 election, the project will undertake a Rapid Gender Analysis to map potential women aspirants, with a focus on project beneficiaries, including women peace actors who may be interested in transitioning to political leadership. The analysis will also identify the barriers to the full and effective participation of women, including young women, in electoral and political processes.



The recommendations arising from this analysis will inform strategic engagement in the two counties in 2026 and beyond. The study will also contribute to knowledge on women's political participation in Kenya's counties.

Donor Recognition

UN Women acknowledges the Government of Ireland for its vital support in advancing women's leadership and inclusive governance in Bungoma and Vihiga counties. In 2024, Ireland's contributions enabled over 1,290 women to strengthen their leadership capacities and meaningfully engage in peacebuilding, governance, and accountability processes. As a result, 90 percent of targeted women reported increased agency and influence in public life. Through Ireland's support, women peace actors led reviews of local peace accords, submitted gender-responsive memoranda, and operationalized early warning forums across four sub-counties. Five county-level policies on gender equality, disability inclusion,

and child protection were also adopted. Ireland's investment further supported the implementation of County Action Plans on UNSCR 1325 and institutionalized Women's Leadership Pillars within county structures. UN Women sincerely thanks the Government of Ireland for its steadfast partnership in advancing gender equality and promoting women's voices in local governance and peace processes in Kenya.

UN WOMEN IS THE UN ORGANIZATION DEDICATED TO GENDER EQUALITY AND THE EMPOWERMENT OF WOMEN. A GLOBAL CHAMPION FOR WOMEN AND GIRLS, UN WOMEN WAS ESTABLISHED TO ACCELERATE PROGRESS ON MEETING THEIR NEEDS WORLDWIDE.

UN Women supports UN Member States as they set global standards for achieving gender equality, and works with governments and civil society to design laws, policies, programmes and services needed to ensure that the standards are effectively implemented and truly benefit women and girls worldwide. It works globally to make the vision of the Sustainable Development Goals a reality for women and girls and stands behind women's equal participation in all aspects of life, focusing on four strategic priorities: Women lead, participate in and benefit equally from governance systems; Women have income security, decent work and economic autonomy; All women and girls live a life free from all forms of violence; Women and girls contribute to and have greater influence in building sustainable peace and resilience, and benefit equally from the prevention of natural disasters and conflicts and humanitarian action. UN Women also coordinates and promotes the UN system's work in advancing gender equality.



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